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Culture (OWC): [Bambara \(FA08\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1946-1949

Coverage Date: Not Specified

Place Coverage: Not Specified

Section Title(S): Faro's Auxiliaries

Numerous articles or essays have already been published on the Bozo. Their language and fishing techniques have been studied. However, inquiries into their religion and the image they have of themselves prove very difficult. This is caused, on the one hand, by their apparent conversion to Islam and, on the other, by their reticence in discussing their traditional system. Such a contribution, however, will be indispensable to scholarship in the study of certain aspects of Sudanese metaphysics, particularly that of the Bambara and the Dogon. The myths of both groups mention the apparition of the Bozo on earth as coinciding with the beginning of 51 Faro's actions which, in turn, coincides with the development of techniques among the Bambara, and with the "third word" of the Dogon (1). In addition, the "joking relationships" which they maintain with the Dogon and which go back to the origin of a whole system of tribal and intertribal alliances clearly indicate the importance of the symbolic role conferred upon them (2).

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Material Not Relevant

Whenever he feels the need, Faro carries women and young girls off to his watery home. Many disappearances in the course of river crossings by canoe are attributed to him.

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Spirits And Gods

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Prayers And Sacrifices

In olden times, each year a young virgin, chosen for her beauty by the griot of the village, became the wife and servant of Faro. In most cases she was willing and proud to become his eternal companion. On a designated day, wearing her finest jewelry, she was  80 brought to the middle of the river and thrown in while the villagers prayed the spirit to give the village his protection and to bring rain to future harvests.

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Spirits And Gods

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Prayers And Sacrifices

1. See M. Griaule, Dieu d'eau.

2. See p. 119, n. 1.

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